

Czech Republic



The landlocked Czech Republic comprises the ancient territories of Bohemia and Moravia.

962 CE The coronation of Otto I marks the beginning of the Holy Roman Empire, of which Bohemia is a founding member.

973 The bishopric of Prague is created.

1200s Under Ottakar I, Bohemia becomes a kingdom, the only one within the Holy Roman Empire.

1222 Ottakar I annexes Moravia after the death of his brother Vladislav, margrave of the territory.

1310 John of Luxembourg marries Elisabeth, the sister of Wenceslas III of Bohemia, and becomes King of Bohemia.

1344 Prague becomes an archbishopric four years before the founding of the Charles University in Prague. Around this time, Prague is considered the third most important city of Europe, after Constantinople and Paris.

1346 The Czech king Charles (son of John of Luxembourg) is crowned Holy Roman Emperor as Charles IV, marking the apogee of the Bohemian kingdom.

1415 The Czech priest and scholar Jan Hus is burnt at the stake after leading a religious reformation. The execution sparks nearly 20 years of civil war.

1419 Hussites seeking to reform Czech society throw prominent Catholic nobles from a Prague castle window in the first "defenestration of Prague."

1526 Bohemia comes under the rule of the Austrian Habsburgs.

1618 Rising tensions between Catholics and Protestants result in another defenestration that marks the beginning of the 30 Years War.

1620 Protestant nobles seeking to break Habsburg rule are beaten at the Battle of the White Mountain outside Prague.

1740 Prussia invades Silesia, which has belonged to Bohemia since the 14th century. The 1745 Treaty of Dresden confirms Prussian control over Silesia, except for a small part in the east known as Austrian Silesia.

1781 Under Habsburg King Josef II, an edict of tolerance benefits both Protestants and Jews. Serfdom is also abolished, although the feudal system is not. German is decreed the sole administrative language of Bohemia and Moravia.

1848 Czech nationalist Frantisek Palacky and the Czech authorities refuse to participate in the elections held within the German Confederation (of which Bohemia forms a part) in contrast to the Germans in Bohemia and Moravia who wish to be part of a unified Germany.

1918 After the defeat of Austria-Hungary in World War I, Czechoslovakia is established as a democratic state comprising the Czech Lands of Bohemia and Moravia, and Slovakia. Tomas Masaryk becomes president.

1938 German-speaking Sudetenland is incorporated into Nazi Germany after a Munich meeting between Hitler and British prime minister Neville Chamberlain.

1939 Hitler annexes the rest of Czechoslovakia and creates a German "protectorate" of Bohemia and Moravia. The Diet of Bratislava declares Slovakian independence under the protection of the German Reich and the leadership of a former priest, Jozef Tiso.

1942 The assassination of Nazi "protector" Reinhard Heydrich prompts reprisals, including the murder of the male population of the village of Lidice.

1945 Edvard Benes, president of the government-in-exile in London, reaches an agreement in Moscow with the exiled communist leader Klement Gottwald on the formation of a multi-party National Front.



CZECH STATESMAN (1921–92)

ALEXANDER DUBCEK

A Slovak communist and a fighter in the Slovak Resistance in 1944, Alexander Dubcek (1921–92) led the Slovak Communist Party from 1958 until he took over the leadership of Czechoslovakia in January 1968.

As leader of the "Prague Spring" of 1968, he tried to introduce communism with a human face, relaxing its totalitarian grip on power without ending its rule. The policy failed when Warsaw Pact troops invaded in August and he was arrested, and later expelled from the party. After the Velvet Revolution of 1989, he became speaker of the federal assembly.

1946 The communists poll 38 percent of the vote in a general election. Gottwald, as leader of the largest party, is invited to lead an all-party coalition government.

1948 President Benes swears in a new communist-dominated cabinet led by Gottwald, which takes power in the "Prague coup" after intimidation by the Communist Party (CPCz) leads non-communists to resign from government.

1948 The Social Democratic Party is merged with the CPCz.

1948 A new constitution declares Czechoslovakia a people's democracy.

1950 The start of a wave of political show trials ushers in purges and executions of party members and officials.

1968 The "Prague Spring," an attempt at liberalization led by Alexander Dubcek, is ended as the USSR and other Warsaw Pact countries invade.

1989 As communist rule weakens throughout eastern Europe, Civic Forum, led by playwright Vaclav Havel, takes to the streets in mass, peaceful demonstrations to demand the end of communist rule and free elections. The "Velvet Revolution" achieves its aims and the free elections are won by Civic Forum with Havel as president.

1992 A two-party system is established as Civic Forum falls apart. Vaclav Klaus of the right-of-center Civic Democratic Party (ODS) becomes prime minister in 1997, facing the opposition left-of-center Czech Social Democratic Party (CSSD).

1993 Amicable division of Czechoslovakia into the Czech Republic and Slovakia.

1998 Start of EU membership negotiations

1999 Joins NATO.

2003 Vaclav Havel steps down as president and is succeeded by former prime minister Vaclav Klaus.

2004 Last conscripts join the army as it slims down to become a professional force. Czech Republic joins the EU.

2005 Stanislav Gross resigns as prime minister after allegations about his financial affairs.

2006 Elections result in a hung parliament. A center-right coalition is approved by parliament in 2007.

2008 Czech Republic agrees to host part of new US missile defense system.

2010 Left-wing Social Democrats win most votes in general election, but the second-place Civil Platform (OSD) forms a coalition government with smaller parties.

«306–07 The Napoleonic Wars
«448–49 Raising the Iron Curtain

Slovakia



Once part of Czechoslovakia, the country is now an independent state.

900s The Slav peoples of the region fall under Hungarian rule, and remain part of the Hungarian or Austro-Hungarian empire until 1918.

1918 Becomes part of new state of Czechoslovakia.

1939–45 After the dismemberment of Czechoslovakia by Nazi Germany, Slovakia becomes a puppet pro-Nazi state under Jozef Tiso.



Puppet priest

A Nazi officer looks on approvingly as Father Jozef Tiso (1887–1947), head of the pro-Nazi Slovak puppet state, gives a speech during World War II. Tiso was executed for treason in 1947.

1944 Slovak National Uprising by Slovak partisans against German rule is savagely crushed with huge loss of life.

1945 Czechoslovak state restored.

1948 Communists seize power.

1989 "Velvet Revolution" introduces democracy.

1992 Vladimir Meciar of the Movement for a Democratic Slovakia, wins election proposing independence for Slovakia.

1993 Separate Slovak and Czech states are established after the two nations part peacefully in the so-called "Velvet Divorce."

1998 Coalition wins election. It includes Hungarian Coalition Party representing the 10-percent Hungarian minority, thus reducing ethnic tension in the country.

2004 Slovakia joins EU and NATO.

2009 Slovakia adopts the euro. Laws passed fining anyone using a minority language inside government buildings.

«186–87 The Black Death
«448–49 Raising the Iron Curtain